

BEFORE

Indus Valley culture grew largely out of developing farming cultures west of the valley.

EARLY FARMING CULTURES

Most notable was the Neolithic **Mehrgarh** culture, starting c. 7000 BCE in modern Pakistan.

HARAPPAN PHASES

The “Early Harappan” phase of the Indus Valley culture (c. 3300–2800 BCE) saw the first examples of the **Indus script**, more **sophisticated agriculture**, and **growing trade links**.



Indus Valley script

Indus valley seals are rich sources of imagery, featuring animal, human, and mythical figures alongside samples of the undeciphered script.

The Indus Valley civilization peaked between about 2600 and 1900 BCE, in what is often called its “Mature Harappan” period. It flourished across an extensive area of present-day northwest India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan, along the fertile Indus and Ghaggar-Hakra rivers.

At its height, the Indus Valley ranked among the first great early civilizations, in the company of Mesopotamia and Egypt (see pp.54–57). Like them, it depended heavily on farmland nourished by major rivers. Also in common with them, its people developed expert knowledge about how to harness and control the annual flooding patterns of the rivers.

Artistic skills

The refined artifacts produced in the Indus Valley region clearly show this to have been an advanced civilization. They include finely worked jewelry in gold and fired steatite (soapstone); figurines fashioned from bronze, terra-cotta, and faience; pottery; gold and



Indus rulers

This famous figure from Mohenjo-Daro is known as “the priest-king”, despite no evidence of rule by priests or kings.

silver ornaments; and seals. The latter often featured images of animals common to the area, such as elephants and zebu (oxen).

These artifacts seem to tell us that there was not only skill, but also prosperity and an elite class, which hints further at a society with different social and economic levels. There are quite a few different artistic styles, too, perhaps pointing to a diverse ethnic mix within the population.

Some Indus Valley artifacts, most famously the jewelry, have been found at sites elsewhere in the world, indicating widespread trading links. The Indus people relied heavily on

trading arrangements and their partners included Mesopotamia (see right), Iran, and Afghanistan. Trading practice was boosted by advances in methods of transportation, especially in boats suited to long-distance travel along sea routes. Sets of weights have also been found among excavated artifacts, and the Indus people seem to have been among the first to develop a precise weights



Advanced sanitation

Highly developed plumbing included drains (above), some of which were covered, and latrines. To give each dwelling access to clean water, wells were built with high, sealed walls to avoid contamination problems.

Mohenjo-Daro

The city’s grid pattern is visible here. Archaeologists have guessed at its structure by giving certain excavated areas names such as “Citadel Mound,” “Lower Town,” and “the Great Bath,” but these remain contentious issues.

HOW WE KNOW

TRADE WITH MESOPOTAMIA

Maritime trading connections with Mesopotamia were especially important to the Indus Valley civilization. We know that they traded with Mesopotamia as Indus or Indus-influenced artifacts have been excavated there—notably a set of etched carnelian beads, like those below, found at the city of Ur in the tomb of Queen Puabi, c. 2550–2400 BCE.

CARNELIAN BEADS

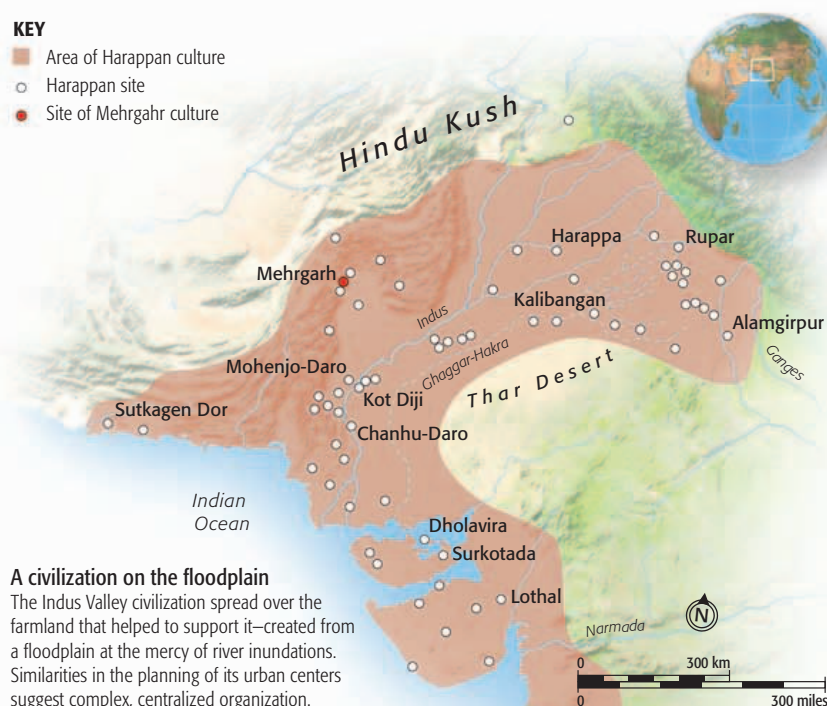


Mysteries of the Indus

A fertile cradle of river-fed land, crossing parts of modern India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan, gave birth to the Indus Valley culture. People in its impressive, well-planned cities lived a refined life, but unlocking more about them is tantalizingly out of reach, as their script remains mostly undeciphered.

KEY

- Area of Harappan culture
- Harappan site
- Site of Mehrgarh culture



A civilization on the floodplain

The Indus Valley civilization spread over the farmland that helped to support it—created from a floodplain at the mercy of river inundations. Similarities in the planning of its urban centers suggest complex, centralized organization.

and measures system. Behind this system lay the kind of expert knowledge that explains why their city buildings were so impressive.

The world’s first town planners?

A large number of settlements are associated with Indus Valley culture. The most spectacular, Mohenjo-Daro and Harappa (in modern Pakistan), were probably the world’s first planned cities. Here were broad avenues and narrow side streets lined with spacious townhouses, all set out in a well-defined grid pattern. Remarkably, Indus cities thousands of miles apart were laid out in a similar way, suggesting a centralized state and local civic organization. Whether there was such a structure, and other details about government and society, remain largely a mystery, as although many distinct symbols appear on Indus artifacts, they remain undeciphered and their secrets locked away.

AFTER

The Indus Valley civilization went into an unexplained decline, with most of its main cities deserted by c. 1700 BCE.

MOHENJO-DARO

The city suffered **severe flooding** in the 1700s BCE, and was laid waste by unknown attackers.

LIFE IN THE VALLEY

Part of the river system may have dried up, overstressing the cities’ resources, although some southern settlements endured. Later Asian civilizations, such as the **Vedic 124 >>** and **Hindu cultures** of the 1st millennium BCE, reveal cultural aspects of the Indus Valley civilization.